



Society for Academic Freedom and Scholarship

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20 October 2020

Jacques Frémont
President and Vice-Chancellor
University of Ottawa
Tabaret Hall
Ottawa ON K1N 6N5

Dear Mr Frémont,

I am writing as president of the Society for Academic Freedom and Scholarship (SAFS), an organization of university faculty members and others dedicated to the defense of academic freedom and the merit principle in higher education. (For further information, see our website at www.safs.ca.)

SAFS, and everyone who cares about good teaching, academic freedom, and the academic mission of the university, is delighted to know that Verushka Lieutenant-Duval has returned to the classroom to continue teaching her course on gender identities in the visual arts.

Nonetheless, the incident raises serious questions about academic freedom in teaching and academic leadership at the University of Ottawa. First, why was any action at all taken against Dr Lieutenant-Duval and why was she not reinstated immediately? Second, why were the students and others who complained about her lecture not directly told that Dr Lieutenant-Duval did

nothing wrong during her lecture? Finally, why was a new section of the course created?

Dr Lieutenant-Duval did not slur or demean any student or anyone else during her lecture, as you agree. The allegation that she did should have been handled by explaining to those who complained that mentioning a word is not using it and that not all uses of a word often used as a slur are themselves slurs (there is no slur without a slurring). The University of Ottawa could have simply affirmed Dr Lieutenant-Duval's academic freedom in teaching and informed the students that their complaint was groundless.

Instead of explaining to the complainants that Dr Lieutenant-Duval did nothing wrong, the University of Ottawa suspended her. Once that mistake occurred, her dean and other academic administrators should have immediately sought to correct it. Suspending her was a serious mistake but it would have been easy to rectify it in just a day.

You are quoted as saying that creating a second section of the course for those students who falsely believe themselves to have been demeaned is “a necessary step to accommodate and respect the rights of all.” In fact, it confirms the students in their misapprehension and, thereby, is inconsistent with the university’s mission to educate. It also expresses doubt toward Dr Lieutenant-Duval’s teaching. What of the new teacher? Does he or she possess the freedom to teach as he or she feels best or is there now an expectation in place that he or she will not follow Dr Lieutenant-Duval’s teaching choices?

In all, taking the complaint seriously, not explaining to the students its groundlessness, and adding a second section to mollify the students cannot but have a bad effect on teaching and learning at the University of Ottawa. Professors and students will now worry if being candid and sincere will get them into trouble, and some students might seek to evade their responsibilities by turning on their teachers, expecting the administration to side with them.

We respectfully request that you respond to our letter. With your permission, we will post your response along with this letter on our website.

Sincerely,

A handwritten signature in black ink, appearing to read 'Mark Mercer', with a stylized, flowing script.

Mark Mercer, PhD
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